Ukraine loan stirs the budget pot

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【メール原文】

Presented by TikTok By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with MAX GRIERA and SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC GREETINGS. It’s Nick Vinocur. Let’s dive in. WHILE YOU WERE SLEEPING:

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GREETINGS. It’s Nick Vinocur. Let’s dive in.

WHILE YOU WERE SLEEPING: Brazil’s President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva defied expectations to win a historic fourth term , securing 51.8% of the vote after a chaotic end to Sunday’s presidential runoff. But his far-right rival Flávio Bolsonaro, who won the first round earlier this month, has refused to concede defeat and demanded that the election be annulled.

VUČIĆ CONCEDES: Aleksandar Vučić’s 12-year grip on power in Serbia ended last night as he acknowledged that his Serbian Progressive Party had been defeated in the parliamentary election by the Student List protest movement. Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President António Costa congratulated Student List, offering to support democratic reforms and to “work together to advance Serbia’s future in the European Union.”

In today’s Playbook:

— We crack the mystery of the EU’s missing Strategic Foresight report.

— Why the European Parliament is weighing whether to anonymize immunity proceedings.

— Faces in the crowd: Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Edouard Philippe, Jean-Luc Mélenchon, Michel Barnier, Arianna Podestà, Ursula von der Leyen, Björn Seibert, Espen Barth Eide and more …

On today’s Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick unpack the beef that’s still simmering ahead of the EU-Canada summit.

A message from TikTok: Did you know TikTok advertising generated €31 billion in economic output across the EU in 2025? New research shows the platform helped businesses grow, supporting €13 billion in additional economic output for small and medium-sized businesses and helping millions of businesses reach customers across borders.

DRIVING THE DAY

UKRAINE COLLIDES WITH THE BUDGET TALKS: EU leaders are preparing to seek a deal on a roughly €45 billion support package for Ukraine by the end of this year, according to five EU diplomats and officials who spoke to me and Bjarke Smith-Meyer.

The potential loan, which would be guaranteed by the current EU budget, has emerged in recent weeks as the most likely scenario for Europe to meet Ukraine's financial needs in 2027. The EU has also been trying to garner more contributions from other allies such as Canada and the United Kingdom, while Belgium continues to oppose the use of immobilized Russian assets to help Ukraine.

But the push for the support package — which would amount to about two-thirds of the €70 billion requested by Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy — coincides with difficult talks about the EU's next long-term budget. And it will likely aggravate tensions between countries that provide the bulk of support for Ukraine and those that contribute comparatively little.

Not for us, thanks: Countries that previously opted out of the EU's last major loan for Ukraine — a €90 billion package agreed last December — are signaling they plan to do so again. The leaders of Czechia and Slovakia indicated at this month's European Council that they wouldn't take part in the loan, and Hungary is also likely to opt out, two of the diplomats said. The diplomats were granted anonymity to discuss the sensitive plans.

The cost of opting out: Ukraine's biggest backers in the bloc warn that they might be less inclined to support demands from the so-called "Friends of Cohesion" group pressing for a larger EU budget if some of those countries don't show solidarity with Kyiv.

"How can anyone seriously believe that our taxpayers would be willing to send even one more euro in cohesion funds to those who refuse to take part in defending against the greatest threat to the security of us all?" a German diplomat told my colleague Hans von der Burchard.

But another EU diplomat argued that the EU needs to find a way to fund Ukraine and to ensure the cohesion funds that many countries in the bloc depend on. "Politically, it would not be easy to explain that we have found money for Ukraine but we had to proceed with massive cuts in EU policies for Europeans," that diplomat said. "It would be better to fund both."

When to watch: The question of how exactly to structure the potential new loan for Ukraine will be on the table when leaders gather on Nov. 26, with the European Commission expected to lay out the different options in a paper. The size of any support package is likely to fluctuate depending on how much help Ukraine gets from NATO allies, how much can be mobilized from existing EU funds and how much military aid (particularly missile interceptors) Kyiv can secure.

BIG AND BREAKING

THE SICKEST MAN OF EUROPE: After two weekends of mass protests marred by episodes of violence, France is being dragged into a vicious cycle of fiscal and social crises . The EU's second-biggest economy is "on the brink of a financial crisis," former Prime Minister Michel Barnier tells my colleagues Giorgio Leali and Clea Caulcutt in Paris.

Philippe slips: Centrist former PM Edouard Philippe is losing ground to far-left challenger Jean-Luc Mélenchon in the French presidential race, according to polling conducted exclusively for POLITICO . Marine Le Pen remains comfortably in the lead.

SEATS AT THE TABLE: The EU will be represented at the next Ukraine talks by the Commission and Council, per Commission spokesperson Arianna Podestà and another EU official. Diplomats raised eyebrows when only von der Leyen's chief of staff Björn Seibert was present in Miami and Oslo, leaving António Costa's top aide Pedro Lourtie out in the cold.

FUNDING FLOWS AGAIN: Norway will resume funding Hungary via the EEA and "Norway grants," to the tune of €254.1 million for the 2021-2028 period, after payments were suspended for a decade amid disagreements over human rights with the government of former PM Viktor Orbán. "In reality, we can have payments all the way until 2031 because this has been delayed," Norwegian Foreign Minister Espen Barth Eide told Playbook.

Don't tell Donald Trump: The U.S. president slammed Norway as a "shithouse country" at a campaign rally in Michigan last night. He's fuming that he hasn't yet been awarded the Nobel Peace Prize.

THE MYSTERY OF THE MISSING REPORT

LACKING FORESIGHT: A report intended to help the EU prepare for a more dangerous future appears to have an uncertain future of its own, with four officials telling Sebastian Starcevic it has been delayed with no publication date in sight.

Geopolitical laundry list: European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen launched the Strategic Foresight Report in 2020 at the height of the Covid-19 pandemic to take stock of the various challenges facing the EU. The document, published annually, tracks the long-term forces shaping the bloc — from climate and technological change to geopolitical upheaval — and shapes policy priorities.

But the 2026 edition has yet to be seen. The report, helmed by Youth Commissioner Glenn Micallef, was last on the College agenda in July and has not surfaced since. It was supposed to be published around the time of von der Leyen's State of the Union speech in September, one of the officials said.

Open question: The report will be published "in the following months," a Commission spokesperson told Playbook. They didn't specify a date or confirm whether the report is still set to be officially adopted by the College or whether it has been downgraded in importance.

More open questions: EU officials who spoke to Playbook offered varying explanations for the holdup, ranging from delays within the cabinet to more important files taking precedence. The Commission spokesperson didn't give a reason for the delay.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Christine Lagarde is expected to leave her role as president of the European Central Bank ahead of time. She also sits on the ECB's six-person executive board … but who else is on it and what does it do? The board sets the agenda for Governing Council meetings (which define monetary policy for the euro area and set key interest rates) and manages the day-to-day running of the ECB. It currently consists of

Lagarde, Vice President Boris Vujčić and four other ECB members.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked what you think about meat-free snacks using names like “bacon” to describe their flavor. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

PARLIAMENT DEBATES IMMUNITY RULES

OUT OF PUBLIC VIEW: The European Parliament is weighing whether to anonymize immunity proceedings to shield lawmakers under investigation from public scrutiny, three people familiar with the discussions told Max Griera. The proposal is part of an overhaul of how the Parliament handles requests from prosecutors seeking to investigate MEPs.

Under existing rules, once the Parliament receives an immunity waiver request from law enforcement, President Roberta Metsola announces it — including the name of the lawmaker under question — at the next plenary session. Some MEPs want the announcement to take place only after the legal affairs committee has decided to lift the immunity, while deleting any names from the agendas and minimizing internal documents to avoid leaks.

Past controversy: In 2025, Belgian authorities submitted and then withdrew a request to waive the immunity of MEP Giusi Princi in the space of 24 hours. In 2026, the prosecutor wrongly accused MEP Daniel Attard of receiving payments from Chinese bank accounts after mixing him up with a businessman of the same name.

But there could be a cost to shielding MEPs. Anonymizing lawmakers under investigation risks leaving the public “completely in the dark,” said one of the people familiar with the plans, granted anonymity to speak about the proposal.

The push comes amid broader anger around perceived politicization of immunity proceedings, after years of political groups horse-trading over the protection of MEPs . EPP lawmakers voiced frustration at a group meeting in September about the lifting of MEP Matej Tonin’s immunity. The ongoing reforms are intended to “better protect MEPs,” a senior lawmaker said at that meeting, according to internal minutes obtained by Playbook.

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

COMPETING VISIONS: Canada wants to create an alliance of so-called middle powers with the European Union ⋯ but the EU doesn’t see itself as a middle power at all , Zi-Ann Lum, Sebastian Starcevic and Camille Gijs write.

GREEN GOALS UNDER THREAT: The ECB’s commitment to green finance is likely to be tested if Christine Lagarde leaves Frankfurt early, Johanna Treeck reports .

SATELLITE DILEMMA: A proposed space merger hailed as a potential European “champion” could drive up costs as the bloc builds its own secure satellite communications, Francesca Micheletti and Jacopo Barigazzi report.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy, with rain in the afternoon. High of 13C.

WILD BOYS ARE BACK: Duran Duran hits the ING Arena tonight for the band's first Brussels concert since January 2012. Back then, Britain was still in the EU, Croatia was out, and Schuman roundabout was arguably messier but definitely less ugly. Tickets for the concert are still available — but if Duran Duran isn't your "Ordinary World," here's another way to spend Monday.

ROAD TO THE DEAD: The Marolles' Mexican-inspired Día de Muertos celebrations kick off tonight with the unveiling of the Grand Altar of the Dead outside Centre culturel Bruegel (Rue des Renards 1F), from 7 p.m. to 9:30 p.m. Expect giant skeletons, lanterns, live music from Banda Quetzal, mezcal and hot chocolate. Bring photos, flowers or messages to remember your loved ones.

Death takes a walk too: The festivities continue through Nov. 1, with the grand procession on Halloween, Oct. 31. Starting at 7 p.m. from Boulevard du Midi/Rue des Tanneurs, giant puppets, musicians and dancers will wind through the Marolles, reaching Place du Jeu de Balle around 8:30 p.m. Everyone's invited to dance with the dead.

BRUNNER'S WARNING GETS A RESPONSE: In an interview with POLITICO earlier this month, EU migration chief Magnus Brunner urged Brussels Airport to get a handle on passport control lines for non-European travelers before Christmas. The airport has now announced it will add eight more booths in December. The delays are linked to the EU's new Entry/Exit System, which records fingerprints and facial images of non-EU travelers entering Schengen.

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TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is in Asia all week, while back home his government is unveiling plans for more affordable housing amid mounting anger over rental costs.

Paris: Our presidential poll shows what some of Edouard Philippe's aides were already saying privately — he's struggling to get his vision across.

Madrid: Spain's parties are finalizing their election lists , exposing internal rivalries and uneasy alliances as the campaign heats up.

London: Andy Burnham will be front and center of the debate in Westminster with just two days to go until the budget, announcing more funding to tackle rough sleeping — one of his signature political issues.

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AGENDA

— E5 defense ministers meeting in Paris. Attendees include EU High Representative Kaja Kallas, Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius and NATO Deputy Secretary-General Radmila Šekerinska. A press conference is scheduled for 5 p.m. Watch live .

— Coreper II meets at 2 p.m.

— Agriculture and Fisheries Council in Luxembourg, attended by Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen and Fisheries Commissioner Costas Kadis. Ministers will discuss the post-2027 Common Agricultural Policy and seek agreement on 2027 fishing limits in the Baltic Sea. Press conference around 7:30 p.m. Watch live .

— Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto attends the fifth Festival of Regions and Autonomous Provinces in Florence.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica virtually attends the foundation-stone-laying ceremony for Croatia's National Children's Hospital in Zagreb.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall receives Michel Forst, the United Nations special rapporteur on environmental defenders under the Aarhus Convention, in Brussels.

— European Hydrogen Week opens in Brussels, bringing together policymakers and industry for a high-level policy conference on hydrogen. The event is co-organized by the European Commission, Hydrogen Europe and the Clean Hydrogen Partnership. It starts at 1 p.m. and runs through Friday, Oct. 30.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEPs Eva Kaili, Cristian Dan Preda, Max Andersson and Jordi Solé; European Environment Agency's Caroline Zickgraf; NYT's Mark Landler; ADF International's Robert Clarke; former U.S. Secretary of State Hillary Clinton. Austrian National Day.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Gregorio Sorgi and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

A message from TikTok: Did you know TikTok advertising generated €31 billion in economic output across the EU in 2025? New independent research shows the platform helped businesses grow, acting as a discovery engine for opportunity across the European economy. The impact goes well beyond the app. Advertising on TikTok helped generate €13 billion in additional economic output for small and medium-sized businesses, while more than 6.5 million EU businesses used TikTok to reach customers across borders. Discovery on TikTok helps small businesses connect with new customers, creators reach new audiences, and useful ideas and skills travel between countries. These connections can translate into real-world growth, from increased sales for local businesses to new opportunities for entrepreneurs and creators. Across the EU, TikTok is turning online discovery into economic activity, helping businesses grow and connecting people and products across borders.

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